

Who Is The Greatest?

A Statistical Comparison of Messi, Ronaldo, Haaland & Mbappé *Author: Ingavi Kilavuka | Data: Club careers 2004–2025*

	Lionel Messi	2004 - 2025	21
	Cristiano Ronaldo	2004 - 2025	21
	Erling Haaland	2017 - 2025	9
	Kylian Mbappe	2016 - 2025	9

This report presents statistical findings in plain language. No technical background required.

How We Measured Performance

Raw goal totals are misleading. A player scoring 30 goals in 2,000 minutes is more prolific than one scoring 30 in 3,500 minutes. Every metric here is adjusted for playing time to make comparisons fair.

Metric	Plain-English Meaning	
Goals per 90 min	Goals scored per 90 minutes played	Removes the effect of how much a player featured

Assists per 90 min	Assists per 90 minutes	Measures creativity alongside finishing
Goal Contributions / 90	Goals + Assists combined per 90 min	One number for total attacking output
Dribbles per 90 min	Successful dribbles per 90 min	Ball-carrying ability; creates space for teammates
Key Passes per 90 min	Passes leading to a shot per 90 min	Playmaking — how often a player creates chances
Composite Score	Equal-weighted average of all metrics (standardised)	Single summary score; no arbitrary weights

Two comparison groups: Messi and Ronaldo are compared on all five metrics — both have complete historical data. Haaland and Mbappé are included only on goals and assists per game, as dribble and key pass data could not be reliably sourced for their full careers. Comparing them on incomplete data would be misleading, so those metrics are excluded.

Part 1: Messi vs Ronaldo — The Full Comparison

16 verified seasons each, covering all competitions. This is the richest comparison in the study because both players have complete data across all five metrics.

Goals / 90	0.93	0.94	Negligible	No (p=0.895)	Trivial (r=0.03)	Statistically identical
Assists / 90	0.41	0.23	Messi +78%	Yes (p<0.001)	Large (r=0.80)	Messi clearly higher
GA / 90	1.35	1.17	Messi +15%	No (p=0.068)	Medium (r=0.38)	Trend to Messi, not conclusive
Dribbles / 90	3.76	1.45	Messi +160%	Yes (p<0.001)	Very large (r=0.95)	Messi dominant
Key Passes / 90	2.07	1.42	Messi +46%	Yes (p<0.001)	Large (r=0.77)	Messi clearly higher
Composite Score	+0.52	-0.52	1.0 SD gap	—	—	Messi leads by a full standard deviation

Effect size r : above 0.5 = large, above 0.3 = medium, above 0.1 = small. A large effect means the gap is meaningful, not just statistically detectable.

Player Profiles — Radar Charts



Fig 1. Career averages per 90 min. Goal bars are nearly equal; the gap widens sharply on assists, dribbles, and key passes.

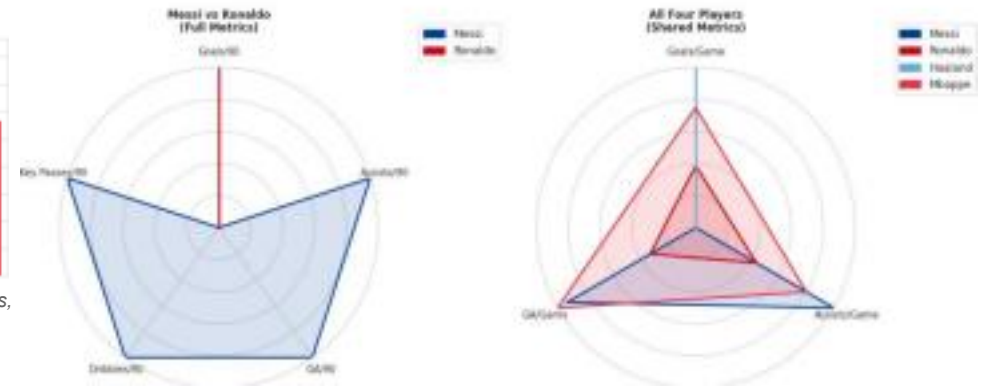


Fig 2. Radar chart showing normalised performance profiles. Messi's shape (blue) covers more ground on

every creative axis.

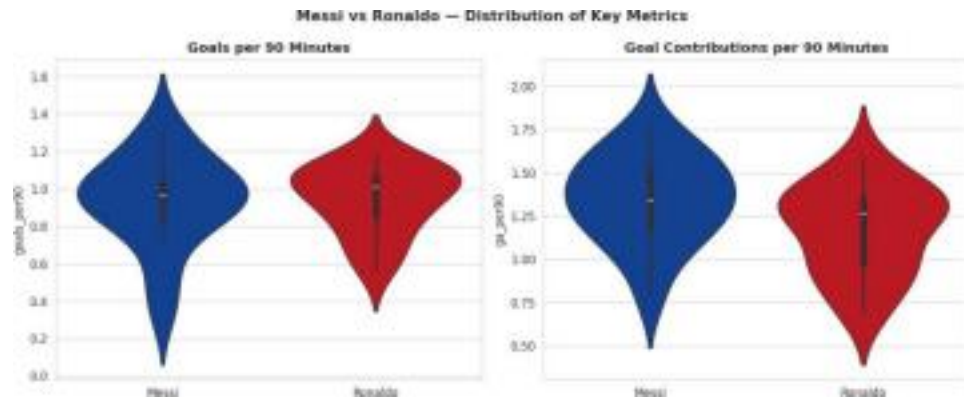
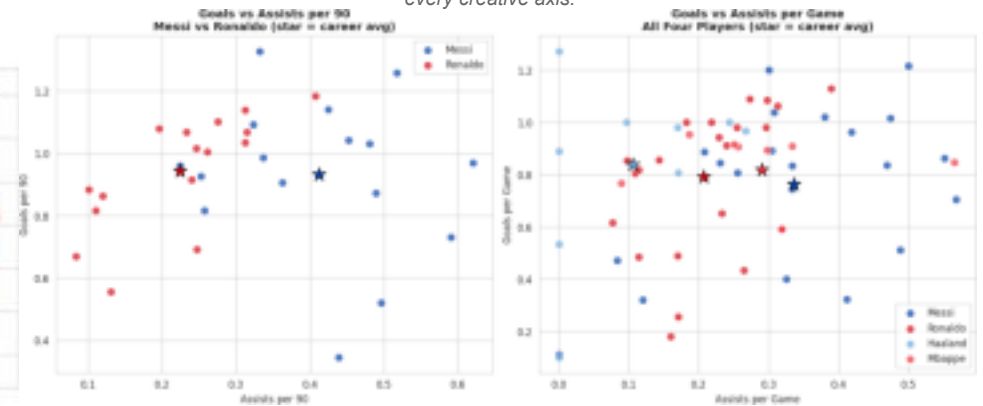


Fig 3. Score distributions across all seasons. Both players were consistent goal scorers. Messi was consistently the stronger creator.

Fig 4. Each dot = one season. Star = career average. Messi sits higher and further right — more goals



AND more assists per 90.

Part 2: All Four Players — Shared Metrics

Because reliable dribble and key pass data is unavailable for Haaland and Mbappé's full careers, this section compares all four on goals and assists per game — the metrics all four share reliably.

Lionel Messi	0.762	0.336	1.099	+0.248	1st
Kylian Mbappé	0.820	0.290	1.110	+0.192	2nd
Cristiano Ronaldo	0.792	0.207	0.999	-0.151	3rd
Erling Haaland	0.839	0.105	0.944	-0.419	4th

Kruskal-Wallis Overall TestsPairwise Assist Comparisons (Bonferroni corrected)

Metric	Overall Difference?	
Goals per Game	No (p=0.785)	All four score at statistically equal rates
Assists per Game	Yes (p=0.0002)	Messi significantly higher than Ronaldo and Haaland
GA per Game	No (p=0.574)	No player is a significantly better all-round contributor

Messi vs Ronaldo	p=0.008 **	Messi significantly higher
Messi vs Haaland	p=0.006 **	Messi significantly higher
Messi vs Mbappé	p=1.000 ns	No significant difference
Haaland vs Mbappé	p=0.035 *	Mbappé significantly higher
Ronaldo vs Haaland	p=0.199 ns	No significant difference
Ronaldo vs Mbappé	p=0.264 ns	No significant difference

Comparison	Adjusted p-value	
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** very significant * significant ns = not significant



Fig 5. Haaland leads on raw goals but trails heavily on assists. Messi and Mbappé lead on total contributions.

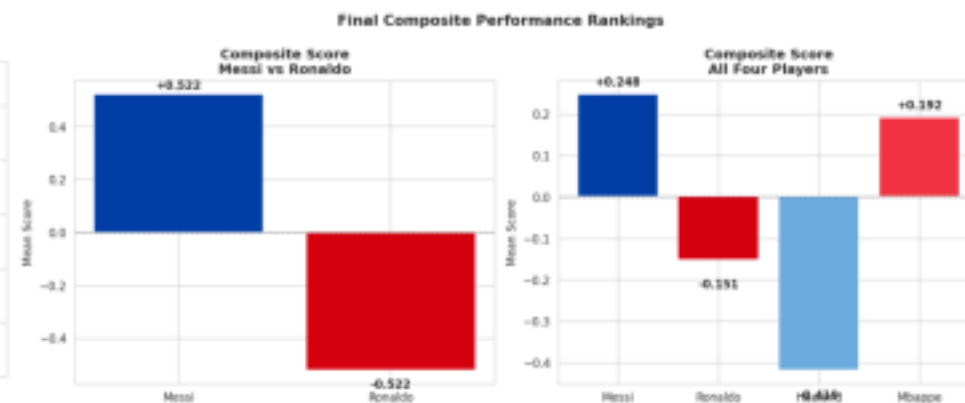


Fig 6. Final composite rankings. Scores above zero are above average. Messi leads both comparison groups.

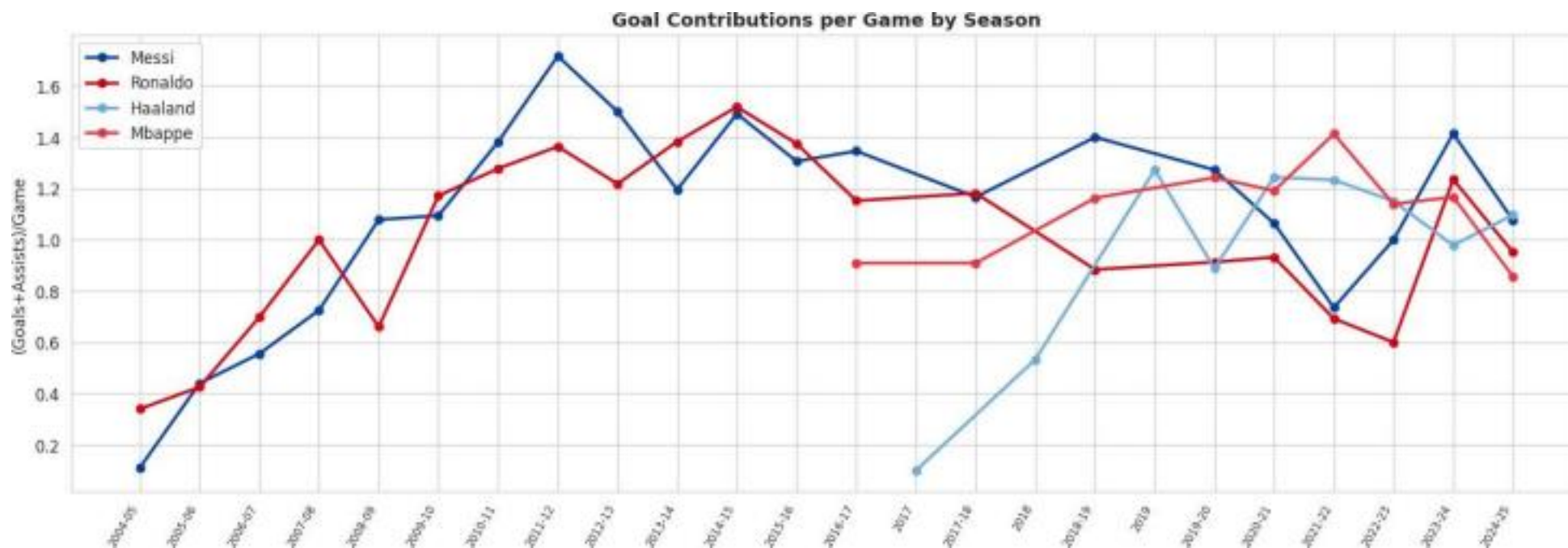


Fig 7. Career trajectory over time. Messi's sustained high output across two decades stands out against the shorter career arcs of Haaland and Mbappé.

The Verdict

The data says: Lionel Messi.

1. All four players score goals at the same rate — so goals alone cannot separate them.

Despite Haaland's reputation as an unstoppable scorer, no player is statistically a better finisher than the others when adjusted for playing time. The debate cannot be settled by goals alone.

3. Assists are the only metric that statistically separates the four players. Messi's assist rate is significantly higher than both Ronaldo's and Haaland's. Mbappé is the only player not significantly behind Messi on assists, making him the strongest modern challenger. Haaland's assist rate (0.105/game) is the lowest of the four confirming he is a

specialist finisher, not a complete attacking player by these metrics.

2. Messi separates himself through creativity, not scoring.

Dribbles per 90 (nearly 3x Ronaldo's rate, $r=0.95$), key passes per 90 (+46%, $r=0.77$), assists per 90 (+78%, $r=0.80$) all statistically significant with large to very large effects. Messi is simultaneously an elite scorer and an elite creator. Nobody else in this group is both.

4. Mbappé is the closest modern rival, but the case is unfinished. Mbappé's composite score (+0.192) is close to Messi's (+0.248), and their assist rates are statistically indistinguishable. But he has only 9 seasons of data versus Messi's 21, and the advanced metrics that most favour Messi are not yet available for Mbappé's full career

Limitations of This Study

The conclusions above are supported by the data, but the following factors should be kept in mind.

1. Data depth is unequal.

Messi and Ronaldo have 16 seasons with full advanced metrics. Haaland and Mbappé lack reliable dribble/key pass data for their full careers, restricting their comparison to goals and assists only. This understates both younger players' full contribution profiles.

2. Career stage imbalance.

Messi's 21 seasons fully capture his historic peak (2009–2015). Haaland and Mbappé have 9 seasons each and are still approaching or in their peaks. Including Messi's record prime years alongside their early careers gives Messi an inherent advantage that will narrow over time.

3. Competition quality varies.

Goals in the Saudi Pro League (Ronaldo at Al Nassr) and MLS (Messi at Inter Miami) are counted the same as Champions League goals. No difficulty adjustment was applied across different leagues and eras.

4. Small samples reduce certainty for Haaland & Mbappé.

With only 9 seasons each, some comparisons may show "not significant" simply because there is not enough data to detect a real difference — not because no difference exists. Results involving these two players should be read as preliminary rather than definitive.